Moshe Koppel, the chairman of Forum Kohelet (the right-wing association standing behind the present Israeli coalition), made a strange declaration. He was not worried if the judicial overhaul didn't get through in the next two or three years; it would get through in any case in the more distant future for the good reason that the rate of reproduction of the Orthodox community in Israel was much higher than that of the secular population. A strange declaration indeed. It did not occur to Mr. Koppel that, at first contact with the modern, secular environment, a sizable segment of initially Orthodox young people will turn away from Orthodoxy and move over to the secular world, as happens with Orthodox Jews in the US, for example, and to a lesser degree in Israel itself, as well as in other religious communities. Or, alternatively, that a segment would remain Orthodox, but politically liberal enough to defend the judicial institutions that their brethren are attacking now.

It has been decided by whatever government authority that Minister Ben-Gvir would be the assigned speaker in Be'er Sheva, at the commemoration ceremony for the soldiers fallen in the wars of Israel, traditionally held on the eve of Independence Day. The Be'er Sheva population is up in arms: they don't want the clown Ben-Gvir, who never served in the army. They decided that they would sing the national anthem, "*Hatikvah,*" with their backs turned on him, during his speech.

The police officer who, a few weeks ago, hurled a stun grenade on demonstrators in Tel Aviv, without any provocation, and badly wounded one of them, tearing off his ear, got the year's distinction award of the Tel Aviv police force. Nice, don't you think?

Friday, April 21

Yesterday, a very emotional speech by retired chief justice Aharon Barak, who, in his day, set the basic legal framework, akin to constitutional laws,